

STUDY SHEET

Like rain upon the grass

Torah: Deuteronomy 32:1–52 · **Haftarah:** Hosea 14:2–10; Joel 2:15–27 · **Gospel:** Matthew 18:21–35

Moses' last song begins with the Word coming down like rain and sets the unchanging Rock against a heart that, in abundance, forgets from whom it received everything. Shabbat Shuvah (Hosea, Joel) calls to return — not to self-made fruit but to its Source — and Matthew 18 shows where that forgetting or returning becomes visible: in how you treat the other.

§0 Observation round

0.1 Blind observation

The song opens with an image of gift: God's teaching comes down like rain and dew (32:2) — it comes toward the earth. At once heaven and earth are called as witnesses (32:1). Then the word Rock (tsur) keeps returning (32:4, 15, 18, 30, 31, 37): God is the Rock, the idols are not. The core of the song is a reversal: God found, carried and fed Israel (the eagle, 32:10–12), but “Jeshurun waxed fat and kicked” (32:15) and “forgot the Rock that begat him” (32:18). Abundance, not the wilderness, becomes the danger. Judgment follows — yet within God's faithfulness to His Name (32:26–27) — and the absolute claim “I kill and I make alive, I wound and I heal” (32:39). The ending: “no empty word, but your life” (32:47), and Moses himself must go up Nebo without entering (32:48–52).

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Does the weight fall on what God is and gives (Source: Rock, rain, dew, healing), on the movement through time (Trajectory: found → carried → fat → forgotten → judged → returned), on the wholeness of inner and outer (Coherence), or on the human response (Will: listen, return, rend your heart)? Do not decide yet.

0.3 The centre of gravity read off

● Load-bearing are **Source** and **Trajectory**: the unchanging Rock against a heart that, over time, forgets from whom it received everything. The chosen gospel (Matt. 18) draws a **Coherence** line through it: forgetting the Rock becomes visible in how you treat the other. Centre of gravity: the Rock who gives and heals, against the forgetting heart — and that forgetting or returning becomes visible in how one treats the neighbour.

0.4 Framing test

● Guarded. The weekly reflex lands on receiving/entrusting. Here the text does not land there: Ha'azinu is a history-in-verse (Trajectory) around a fixed Rock (Source), and the gospel choice Matt. 18 — the unforgiving servant — pushes toward Coherence (inner ↔ outer), not toward surrender. Under guard stays the tendency to sentimentalise the ending into “letting go”; the song is sharp (judgment, ba'at “to kick”), and the teacher himself falls under the Word (Nebo).

§1 The thread

The Word comes down like rain because heaven gives, not because the earth makes it. The Rock does not change; the heart does — especially in abundance, where receiving turns into possessing and the Giver is forgotten. Teshuvah is looking again at the One you left; and whoever returns and grasps how much has been forgiven him treats the other as one who, like him, lives from forgiveness.

§2 Peshat per block

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keyword / contrast	Open question
32:1–3	Heaven and earth as witnesses; the teaching comes down as rain and dew.	witnesses · rain/dew	Why witnesses that endure forever?
32:4–6	The Rock, perfect and right, against a corrupt generation.	tsur (Rock) · right ↔ crooked	Where have we moved away from the Rock?

	Remember of old; God found	remember ·	
32:7–14	and carried Israel like an eagle; abundance.	eagle · abundance	What does the eagle stirring the nest do?
32:15–18	Jeshurun waxed fat, kicked (ba'at), forsook and forgot the Rock that begat him.	waxing fat · forgetting (shayah)	How does abundance grow more dangerous than wilderness?
32:19–38	God hides His face; judgment, but bounded by His Name and the enemy's boast.	hiding the face · Name	How does judgment stand within faithfulness?
32:39–43	“I, even I, am he... I kill and make alive, I wound and heal.”	none other · kill/heal	What remains of every false security?
32:44–52	“No empty word, but your life”; Moses must go up Nebo, not enter (Meribah).	no empty word · Nebo	Why does the teacher fall under the Word?
Hosea 14 / Joel 2	Return; take words; God heals and is “as the dew”; rend your heart, not your garments; blow the trumpet, gather all.	shuv · dew · heart ↔ garments	How does teshuvah sound concretely?
Matt. 18:21–35	A servant is forgiven an immeasurable debt and then seizes his fellow servant by the throat.	forgiveness · forgetting	Where does forgetting/returning become visible?

§3 Two load-bearing axes

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	32:2 (rain/dew) · 32:4,18 (Rock begets/bears) · 32:39 (kill/heal) · Hos. 14:5,8	Load-bearing. The Rock gives, carries and heals; “from Me is your fruit found.”	Why does He hide His face (32:20)?
Trajectory	32:7 (remember) · 32:10–15 (found → fat) · 32:26–27 (judgment bounded) · Hos. 14:1 (return)	Load-bearing, second pole. From found and carried to fat and forgetful to judged to returned.	Is abundance or wilderness the greater test?

		Supporting, and the hinge	
	32:18 (forgetting) · Joel	to the gospel: inner	Does Matt. 18
Coherence	2:13 (heart ↔ garments) ·	(forgetful heart) and outer	pull the centre
	Matt. 18:32–33	(hard hand) belong	away, or serve it?
		together.	
	32:1 (listen) · 32:46–47	Thin as engine; response	Where does
Will	(set your heart) · Hos. 14:2	(listening, returning,	returning become
	(take words)	confessing) follows	a self-chosen
		Source, is not the source.	project?

§4 Sources round

Van de Giessen now covers Deuteronomy (18–34); the rabbinic witnesses were verified via Sefaria.

● **Van de Giessen (pre-peshat).** Tsur (Rock) is the Godname of this song — as refuge/protection — recurring in 32:4, 15, 18, 30, while the idols are precisely no rock (32:31, 37). Jeshurun (32:15) is the symbolic ideal-name for Israel; the verb ba'at (32:15, “to kick / to spurn”) occurs only here and in 1 Sam. 2:29. In 32:18 shayah (“to neglect / forget”) is a hapax, and the Rock “begets and bears” — paternal and maternal language for God being Israel's origin. The song is marked in the text itself by setumot and column layout; DSS witnesses (4QDeut) generally follow MT.

● **Rashi on 32:1 (Sifrei Devarim 306).** Heaven and earth are called as witnesses because they endure forever: Moses is mortal and dies tomorrow; so Israel cannot later say “we never accepted the covenant.” Second reason: the same witnesses reward or punish — the vine yields fruit, the ground its increase, the heaven its dew — or withhold it. That dew note already anchors the image of 32:2 (and Hosea 14) at the peshat.

● **Two witnesses (Deut. 19:15).** Heaven and earth form the pair of witnesses the Torah requires — a legal, not a decorative, move.

● **Midrash Tanchuma (Ha'azinu 2).** Moses says ha'azinu to heaven and “hear” to earth; Isaiah 1:2 reverses the order — the speaker's nearness colours the address. Illustrative, not load-bearing.

● **Onkelos / Ibn Ezra / Ramban** on 32:4/32:15: still to be verified (open verification point).

Revision gate. Did the round shift the centre? Confirming: Rashi's dew note and Van de Giessen's tsur-concentration strengthen Source+Trajectory and the dew-echo to Hosea, without collapsing it to Source alone.

§5 Direction test as horizon

● Confessional. Matthew 18:21–35 continues Ha'azinu's forgetting-line from the other side: the servant forgiven an immeasurable debt who seizes his fellow by the throat is Jeshurun who forgot the Rock — the forgetting becomes visible in the hard hand. “From Me is your fruit found” (Hos.): the fruit of received grace is grace passed on. ● Guarded: Matt. 18 does not determine the peshat of Deut. 32; it is horizon. And “seventy times seven” is no new counting but the end of counting — as the Rock stops counting against the one who returns.

§6 Status table

Claim	Status
The Rock (tsur) is the Godname of the song; idols are no rock (32:4,15,18,31)	● load-bearing
Abundance, not wilderness, becomes the test; forgetting = living as if the Giver were not needed (32:15–18)	● load-bearing
Heaven/earth as eternal and rewarding/punishing witnesses; dew note (Rashi, Sifrei 306)	● load-bearing (verified)
Ba'at only here + 1 Sam. 2:29; shayah hapax (Van de Giessen)	●/● pre-peshat
Moses–Isaiah code-switch (Tanchuma)	● suggestive (aggada)
Reflex-landing on receiving/surrender as endpoint; sentimental “letting go”	● guardrail
Matt. 18: forgetting/returning visible in treatment of the neighbour; the dew-echo (32:2 ↔ Hos. 14:5)	● confessional
Onkelos/Ibn Ezra/Ramban on 32:4/32:15	● open verification point

§7 Podcast rendering

One physical image carries the landing: the field that cannot compel rain. The farmer can plough, sow, fertilise — but he cannot command the sky; the rain comes toward him. So is the Word: gift, not production. And the second half of the image: what grows on your field, you hand out — the fruit of received rain is not a store to lock away but a harvest to pass on.

§8 Source accountability

Van de Giessen, Notes on Deuteronomy (18–34): tsur (32:4,15,18,31), Jeshurun + ba'at (32:15; cf. 1 Sam. 2:29), shayah hapax and “begets/bears” (32:18), setumot/column layout — verified from the file. Rashi on 32:1 (Sifrei Devarim 306) and the two-witnesses (Deut. 19:15) — verified via Sefaria. Tanchuma Ha'azinu 2 🟡. Onkelos/Ibn Ezra/Ramban: still to be verified. Name: Yeshua. Author: Arie Alberts.